

The Renaissance

During the 15th and 16th centuries, art and learning flourished in cities and at royal courts in many parts of Europe, but especially in Italy. The works of the exceptional individuals who made this “renaissance” are among the marvels of the world.

The Renaissance was part of an ongoing process that changed the shape of European culture over many centuries. The term “Renaissance” refers to a “rebirth” of interest in the legacy of ancient Greece and Rome, but the texts of pre-Christian writers had in fact been copied and read in Christian Europe at least from the time of Charlemagne (747–814 CE; see pp.188–89). The paintings of artists such as Giotto, and the writings of Dante, Petrarch, and Boccaccio in the 14th century are among many works that prefigured the Renaissance. The period of the Renaissance is, however,

conventionally dated to around 1450–1550, as a time of exceptional curiosity and inventiveness in European art, architecture, ideas, and technology.



Early book
Baldassare Castiglione's *Book of the Courtier* (1528) was a guide to behavior at a Renaissance court.

Wealth and culture

Economic prosperity was the basis for the Renaissance. Art and learning were luxuries that could be afforded through the increasing wealth of a social elite. The major centers of Renaissance cultural activity were the thriving city-states of Italy, such as Florence, Milan, and Venice, prosperous cities in Germany, and the Flemish Netherlands (see pp.208–09, 276–77). Grown rich on the

proceeds of banking, trade, and manufacture, cities spent freely on cultural luxuries out of civic pride or to enhance the prestige of local rulers such as the Medici family in Florence or the Sforzas in Milan. Wealthy kings such as Matthias Corvinus in Hungary and Francis I in France also patronized artists and intellectuals as a way of advertising their own power and status. Renaissance popes such as Alexander VI (pope from 1492 to 1503) and Julius II (1503–13) made Rome another focus of excellence, lavishing money raised from their Christian flock on extravagant artistic and architectural projects such as St. Peter's Basilica.

The Classical world

The Renaissance was still far from the modern world of science and reason—astrology and alchemy (see p.266) were major fields of study, and one



Dante standing before Florence

Domenico di Michelino painted this image of the poet Dante alongside his native city, Florence. Florence was home to many artists, including architect Brunelleschi, who designed the famous cathedral dome, visible on Dante's left.

Humanist group

Painted by Domenico Ghirlandaio around 1490, this detail from a fresco in the church of Santa Maria Novella in Florence shows a group of humanist scholars including Marsilio Ficino, head of the Platonic Academy.

Michelangelo's David

This massive marble statue was made by Michelangelo for the city of Florence in 1504. Its celebration of the nude male form reflects the influence of classical antiquity, but its subject is the biblical hero David.

of the period's most famous books was *Malleus Maleficarum* (1486), a treatise on hunting witches. Renaissance intellectuals and artists were in a sense backward-looking; self-consciously seeking to learn from and emulate the achievements of the ancient world and to reconcile the best of the wisdom of ancient Greece and Rome with their Christian faith. But they



were also inspired by a confident belief in progress through free enquiry and fresh inventions.

Humanism

The loose international network of scholars who spearheaded the Renaissance are known as “humanists,” reflecting the degree to which they placed humankind, rather than God, at the center of their world-view. A typical treatise published by humanist Pico della Mirandola in 1486 was entitled “On the Dignity of Man.” These scholars studied ancient texts more critically than had been done before, reading in Greek as well as in Latin, which had long been the

BEFORE

In medieval times, some artists and thinkers were already breaking with tradition.

THE FIRST RENAISSANCE

Historians have identified an early “renaissance” in 12th century Europe. **Contact with the Muslim world and the Byzantine Empire** gave access to the works of Islamic and ancient Greek philosophers and scientists << 158–59.

GIOTTO

Florentine artist Giotto di Bondone (c. 1267–1337) initiated a **revolution in European painting** a century before the Renaissance proper. His religious frescoes broke with the conventions of Christian art, showing realistic figures engaged in dramatic scenes.



DANTE'S INFERNO

DIVINE COMEDY

In his epic *Divine Comedy*, describing a journey through Hell and Purgatory to Paradise, Florentine poet Dante Alighieri (1265–1321) combined the classical past with a medieval Christian view of the universe.